

IH03

Mauryas and Post-Mauryan India

Two to three questions a paper. The proven repeats are Bairat and the Bhabru edict (2024), the Barabar caves given to the Ajivikas (2013), and the Parkham yaksha with the Manibhadra inscription (2021). Chronological ordering questions come from this chapter more than any other in Indian History.

India's first pan-Indian empire, and then five hundred years of successor states. The Mauryan half is inscription-driven, which suits RPSC perfectly - edict to place to content. And because Ashoka left two records at Bairat in Jaipur district, this chapter carries a guaranteed Rajasthan angle.

Mauryas & Post-Mauryan India

Mauryan rulers

- Chandragupta c. 322 BCE, with Kautilya
- Bindusara - Amitraghata / Amitrochates
- Ashoka - acceded c. 268 BCE
- Brihadratha killed 185 BCE

Mauryan art

- Chunar sandstone, Mauryan polish
- Sarnath lion capital - State Emblem
- Barabar caves to the Ajivikas
- Parkham yaksha, Didarganj yakshi

Sources

- Arthashastra - 15 books, R. Shamasastri 1905
- Megasthenes' Indica - fragments
- Ashokan edicts - Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Greek, Aramaic
- Junagadh rock - Sudarshana lake

Successors in the north

- Shunga - Pushyamitra, Vidisha
- Kanva - Vasudeva c. 73 BCE
- Kharavela - Hathigumpha
- Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, Kushanas

Edicts & Rajasthan

- 14 Major Rock Edicts
- Minor Rock Edicts - Maski, Gujjarra, Bairat
- 7 Pillar Edicts; PE VII only at Delhi-Topra
- Bairat + Bhabru edict, Bijak-ki-Pahari

Deccan & South

- Satavahana - Simuka, Pratishthana
- Gautamiputra Satakarni, Nashik prashasti
- Sangam - Chera, Chola, Pandya
- Gandhara, Mathura, Amaravati schools

Chandragupta and Bindusara - the founding, and where we learn it from

Chandragupta Maurya founded the empire around 322-321 BCE by overthrowing Dhana Nanda of Magadha, with Kautilya - also called Chanakya and Vishnugupta - as his guide. Within twenty years he had pushed the Greeks back out of the north-west. Learn the treaty with Seleucus, because both the terms and the date are asked.

- Treaty with Seleucus Nicator, c. 305-303 BCE: Chandragupta received Aria, Arachosia, Gedrosia and the Paropanisadai; Seleucus received 500 elephants.
- Megasthenes came to Pataliputra as the Seleucid ambassador.
- Junagadh rock inscription: the Sudarshana lake was built by Pushyagupta, Chandragupta's governor in Saurashtra; conduits were added by the Yavana Tushaspha under Ashoka; Rudradaman I repaired it in 150 CE.
- Jain tradition holds that Chandragupta abdicated, followed Bhadrabahu to Shravanabelagola, and ended his life by sallekhana.
- Bindusara bore the title Amitraghata, which the Greeks wrote as Amitrochates; Deimachus was Antiochus I's ambassador at his court.

The two great sources - know their limits, not just their names

Arthashastra and Indica

Source	Author	What you must remember
Arthashastra	Kautilya	15 books (adhikaranas), 180 prakaranas; manuscript found by R. Shamasastri in 1905, published 1909
Indica	Megasthenes	Survives only in fragments quoted by later classical writers; describes a seven-fold division of Indian society; DENIES that slavery existed in India; says Pataliputra was run by six boards of five members each

- Megasthenes DENIES slavery in India - the planted false statement reads 'it states that slavery was widely prevalent'.
- Do not credit the Sudarshana lake to Rudradaman; he only repaired it in 150 CE. Pushyagupta built it.

Ashoka - the war, the dhamma, the names

Ashoka acceded around 268 BCE. Eight years into his reign, about 261 BCE, he fought the Kalinga war. The killing changed him, and Major Rock Edict XIII is his own account of that remorse. From then on his policy was dhamma - not a religion, but a moral code: non-violence, respect for elders, kindness to servants and animals, and toleration between sects.

- Major Rock Edict XIII describes the Kalinga war and its aftermath, and also names five contemporary Greek kings - the single most useful edict for dating the Mauryas.
- In his inscriptions Ashoka calls himself Devanampiya, beloved of the gods, and Piyadasi, of pleasing appearance.
- His personal name 'Ashoka' appears only at Maski, Gujjarra, Nettur and Udegolam.
- James Prinsep deciphered the Brahmi of the edicts in 1837 - that is what made Ashoka recoverable at all.
- Dhamma Mahamattas, the officers of dhamma, were created in his 14th regnal year.
- He sent missions abroad; his son Mahendra and daughter Sanghamitra carried Buddhism to Sri Lanka.

YAAD RAKHO

Where Ashoka's own name occurs - M-G-N-U: Maski, Gujarra, Nettur, Udegolam. Everywhere else he is only Devanampiya Piyadasi. If a question asks where his personal name is found, the answer is a Minor Rock Edict, never a Major one.

The edicts - the table this chapter is built on

Ashoka's records fall into four families: 14 Major Rock Edicts, the Minor Rock Edicts, 7 Pillar Edicts, and the Minor Pillar and commemorative inscriptions. Plus the two Separate or Kalinga Rock Edicts. Learn the family first, then the individual edict. Almost every question is edict-to-place or edict-to-content.

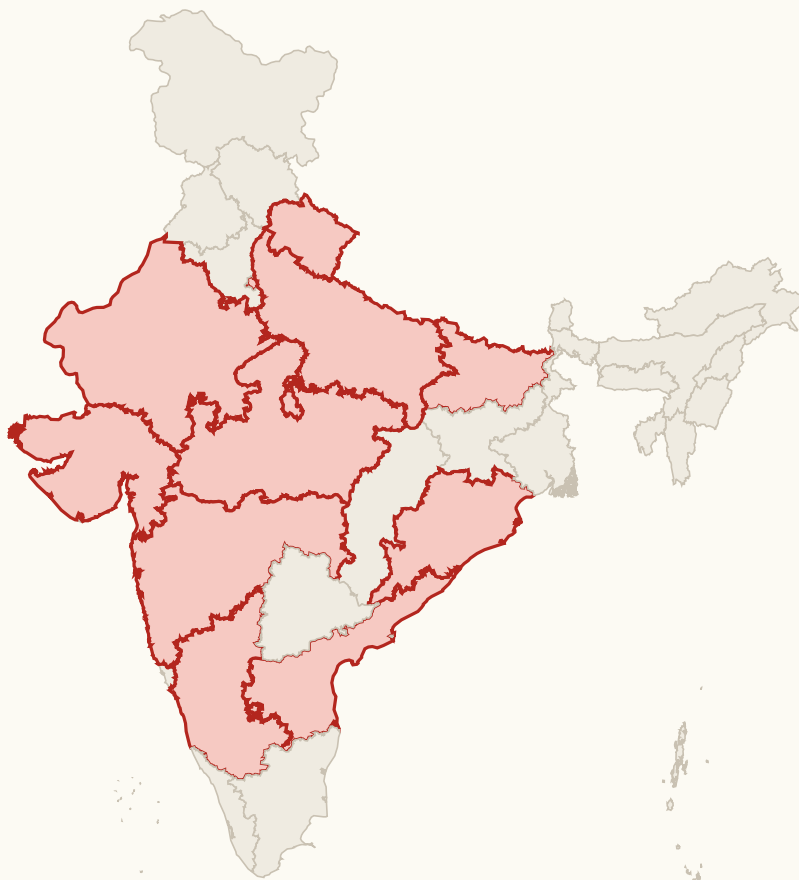
Ashoka's records - family, where they occur, script

Family	Where	Script
14 Major Rock Edicts	Kalsi, Girnar, Sopara, Dhauri, Jaugada, Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra, Yerragudi; later finds at Sannati and Kandahar	Brahmi, except Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra in Kharoshthi and Kandahar in Greek and Aramaic
Two Separate (Kalinga) Rock Edicts	Only at Dhauri and Jaugada	Brahmi
Minor Rock Edicts	Maski, Gujarra, Nettur, Udegolam, Bairat, Rupnath, Sasaram, Brahmagiri and others	Brahmi
7 Pillar Edicts	Delhi-Topra, Delhi-Meerut, Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya-Nandangarh, Rampurva, Allahabad-Kosam	Brahmi
Minor Pillar / commemorative	Sarnath, Sanchi, Allahabad (schism edicts); Rummindei and Nigalisagar	Brahmi

Edict to content - the individual records RPSC actually asks

Edict / record	Place	Content
Major Rock Edict XIII	All the major rock sites	The Kalinga war, Ashoka's remorse, and the five Greek kings
Major Rock Edict XII	Major rock sites	Toleration and respect between religious sects
Separate Rock Edicts I & II	Dhauili and Jaugada only	Instructions to the officers of the newly conquered Kalinga
Pillar Edict VII	Only on the Delhi-Topra pillar	The longest of all the edicts - a review of his dhamma work
Rummindei pillar	Lumbini, Nepal	The village exempted from bali; its produce share fixed at one-eighth
Nigalisagar pillar	Nepal	Records the enlargement of the stupa of Konakamana
Bairat minor rock edict	Bijak-ki-Pahari, Bairat, Jaipur	Ashoka's minor rock edict, still at the site
Bhabru (Calcutta-Bairat) edict	Found at Bairat; now in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata	The only edict where Ashoka openly professes faith in the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha, and recommends named Buddhist texts
Maski minor rock edict	Karnataka	Carries the personal name Ashoka
Barabar cave inscriptions	Barabar hills, Bihar	Dedication of the caves to the Ajivikas

Indian states with Ashokan inscriptions



Kalsi to Karnataka; Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra and Kandahar lie outside India

- Ashokan pillars are cut from Chunar sandstone and carry the distinctive high Mauryan polish.
- Pillar Edict VII, the longest, is found on the Delhi-Topra pillar alone. Not every pillar carries all seven.
- The Allahabad-Kosam pillar is special - besides Ashoka's edicts it carries the Queen's edict and, centuries later, Samudragupta's Allahabad prashasti.

TRAP

Two false statements RPSC has actually planted. First, 'all seven Pillar Edicts occur on every Ashokan pillar' - false, PE VII is on Delhi-Topra only. Second, no set of MAJOR Rock Edicts has been found at Sarnath - Sarnath has a minor pillar (schism) edict and the lion capital, not a rock edict.

Bairat - do this section slowly, it is your Rajasthan mark

Bairat, the old Viratnagar, sits in Jaipur district. It was the capital of the Matsya Mahajanapada, and under the Mauryas it became a Buddhist centre. Two Ashokan records come from Bairat, and RPSC has asked about them directly. Learn both, and learn the difference between them, because the exam separates them.

- Record one - the Bairat minor rock edict, on the hill called Bijak-ki-Pahari.
- Record two - the Bhabru edict, also called the Calcutta-Bairat edict. It was found by Captain Burt and moved to Kolkata; it is now in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata.
- The Bhabru edict is the only Ashokan record in which he openly professes faith in the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha, and it recommends named Buddhist texts to monks and laity.
- Bairat also has India's earliest known free-standing circular Buddhist chaitya - a stupa inside a colonnade of octagonal wooden pillars.
- The Buddhist remains at Bairat were excavated by Daya Ram Sahni - the same man who dug Harappa in 1921.
- Bairat is MATSYA, not Surasena. Surasena's capital was Mathura.
- Do not confuse Bairat in Jaipur with Bagor in Bhilwara - Bagor is the Mesolithic site, Bairat is Buddhist and Ashokan.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 - India's earliest known free-standing circular Buddhist chaitya has been found at Bairat. The same year came the statement set: Bairat has two Ashokan inscriptions (true); the Bhabru edict was found here and later removed to Kolkata (true); Bairat was the capital of the Surasena Mahajanapada (FALSE - Surasena's capital was Mathura; Bairat was Matsya's).

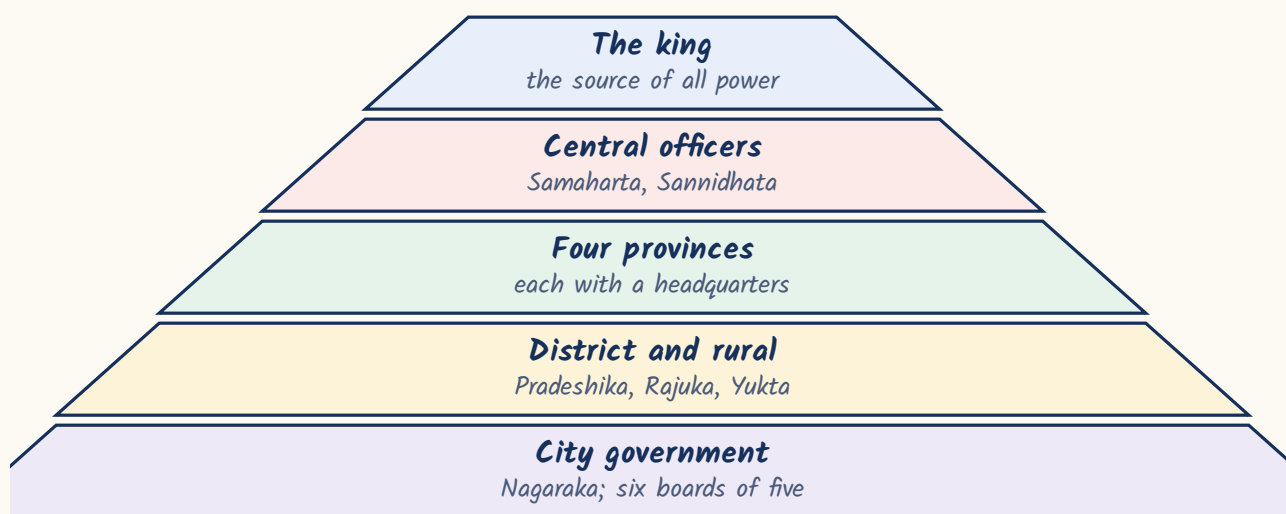
YAAD RAKHO

Bairat = B for Buddhist chaitya, B for Bhabru, B for Bijak-ki-Pahari, B for Burt who found it. Four Bs and you have the whole site.

Mauryan administration - officials and provinces

The Mauryan state was centralised and heavily officered. Learn the offices by function, because the negative-framed question always mismatches one official with one duty.

The Mauryan administrative ladder



Mauryan officials and what they did

Official	Function
Samaharta	Chief collector of revenue
Sannidhata	Treasurer, in charge of the state store-house
Rajuka	Rural administration and the dispensing of justice
Pradeshika	Provincial or district-level supervising officer
Yukta	Subordinate revenue and accounts officer
Nagaraka	Superintendent of the city

Official	Function
Dhamma Mahamatta	Officer of dhamma, created in the 14th regnal year

Provinces and their headquarters

Province	Headquarters
Uttarapatha	Taxila
Avantiratha	Ujjain
Kalinga	Tosali
Dakshinapatha	Suvarnagiri
Imperial capital	Pataliputra

- Megasthenes says Pataliputra was administered by six boards of five members each - thirty officials in all - handling industry, foreigners, births and deaths, trade, manufactures and the sales tax.
- The province-to-headquarters set is a standing matching question; take the four provinces clockwise - north Taxila, west Ujjain, east Tosali, south Suvarnagiri.
- The Rajuka is a RURAL administrator and judge, NOT the head of the royal household - that exact wrong pairing has been used.
- Samaharta is revenue, Sannidhata is treasury. The two get swapped in options.

Mauryan art - pillars, caves, yakshas

Mauryan art divides cleanly into court art, which is imperial and polished, and popular art, which is folk and unpolished. Pillars and caves are court art. The yaksha and yakshi statues are popular art. That division itself is examinable.

The Sarnath lion capital

Four lions

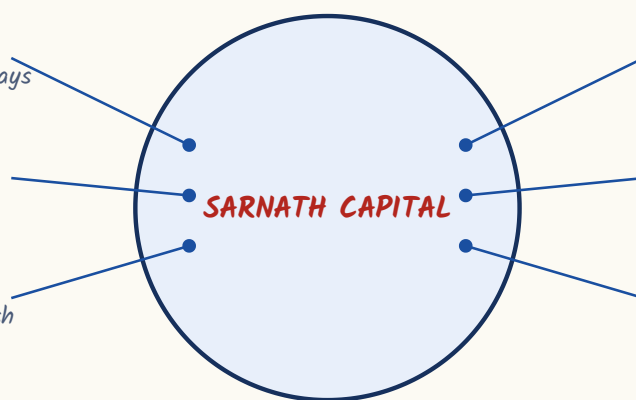
back to back, facing four ways

Dharmachakras

between the four animals

Monolithic shaft

Chunar sandstone, high polish



Abacus

lion, elephant, horse, bull

Inverted lotus

the bell-shaped base

State Emblem

adopted 26 January 1950

- Pillars: monolithic shafts of Chunar sandstone, with the celebrated Mauryan polish, topped by animal capitals - the lion at Sarnath, the bull at Rampurva, the elephant at Sankisa.
- The Sarnath lion capital was adopted as the State Emblem of India on 26 January 1950. Its abacus carries a lion, elephant, horse and bull separated by dharmachakras.
- Barabar hills, Bihar: Ashoka gave the Sudama, Vishvakarma and Karan Chaupar caves to the Ajivikas.
- Nagarjuni hills: his grandson Dasharatha gave the Gopika, Vadathika and Vapiyaka caves to the same sect.
- The Barabar caves are the earliest surviving rock-cut caves in India.
- The Lomas Rishi cave has the famous carved elephant-frieze doorway but carries NO Ashokan inscription.
- The Parkham yaksha near Mathura carries a Brahmi inscription naming the Manibhadra congregation and its maker Gomitaka, pupil of Kunika.
- The Didarganj chauri-bearer yakshi is in the Patna Museum.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2013 - Ashoka donated the rock-cut caves of the Barabar hills to the Ajivikas. Note the link back to the previous chapter: the Ajivikas are Makkhali Gosala's niyati sect.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2021 - the yaksha statue bearing the inscription that mentions the Manibhadra congregation was found at Parkham, near Mathura. The inscription also names its maker Gomitaka, pupil of Kunika.

TRAP

Lomas Rishi has the doorway, not an inscription. The wrong-pair option 'Lomas Rishi cave - an inscription of Ashoka' is a proven RPSC option. Ashoka's cave inscriptions are in Sudama, Vishvakarma and Karan Chaupar.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - the ASI has moved to seek UNESCO World Heritage status for the Barabar and Nagarjuni caves in Jehanabad district, Bihar (reported 2022), and the Bihar government has announced an eco-tourism development for the Barabar hills. They are still on the proposal track, not inscribed. Keep the Ajivika connection in mind if this appears in current affairs.

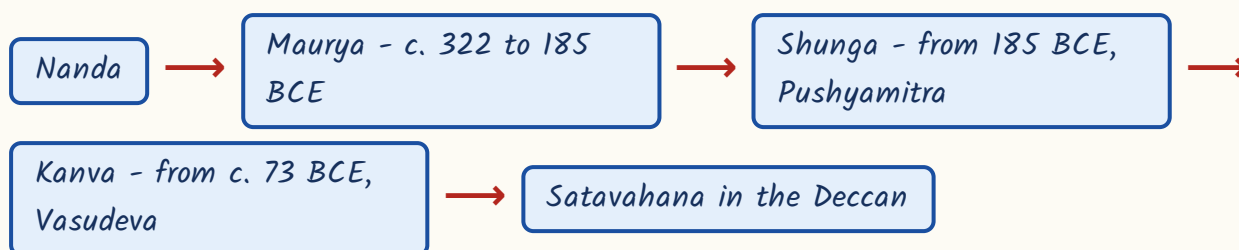
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - the National Emblem cast in bronze for the roof of the new Parliament building was unveiled on 11 July 2022. It is a copy of the Sarnath lion capital, the same capital adopted as the State Emblem of India on 26 January 1950, so a current-affairs item and a Mauryan art question share one answer.

The fall, and the northern successors

The empire lasted about 137 years. In 185 BCE the last Maurya, Brihadratha, was killed by his own commander-in-chief Pushyamitra Shunga on the parade ground. Learn the chain of dynasties after that - it comes as a straight ordering question.

Dynasty chronology in Magadha - the ordering question



- Patanjali's Mahabhashya and the Ayodhya inscription of Dhanadeva connect Pushyamitra with two ashvamedha sacrifices; Patanjali was his contemporary.
- Kalidasa's play Malavikagnimitram is about his son Agnimitra.
- Vidisha was an important Shunga centre.
- The Kanva dynasty was founded by Vasudeva about 73 BCE, after the last Shunga, Devabhuti.
- Kharavela of Kalinga, of the Mahameghavahana or Chedi line, is known from the Hathigumpha inscription in the Udayagiri hills; he patronised Jainism.

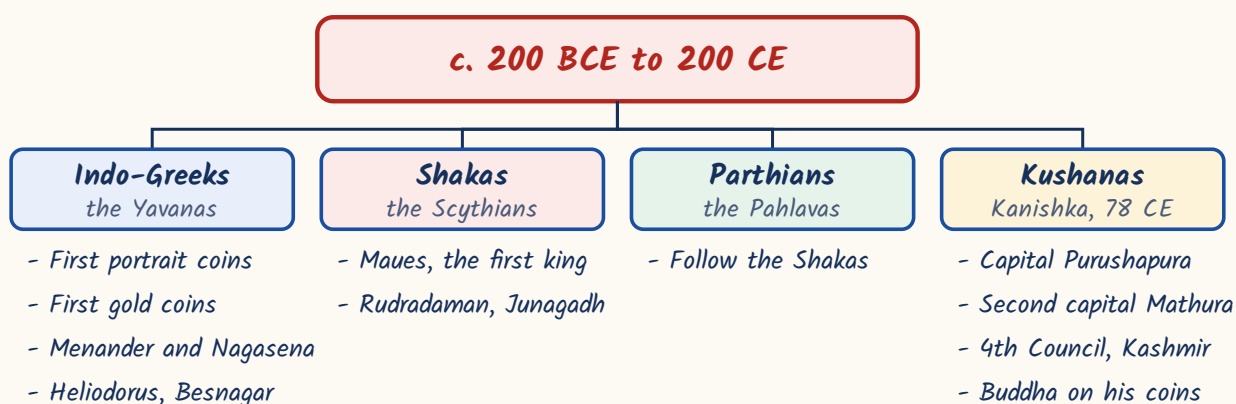
The Satavahanas of the Deccan

- Founder Simuka; capital Pratishthana, modern Paithan on the Godavari.
- Their kings used metronymics - named after the mother, hence Gautamiputra, Vashishthiputra.
- They were the first Indian rulers to grant land to brahmanas.
- The Nashik prashasti of Gautami Balashri praises her son Gautamiputra Satakarni as Ekabrahmana and destroyer of Shakas, Yavanas and Pahlavas.
- That record was issued in the 19th regnal year of Vashishthiputra Pulumavi - the date is asked.
- The Jogalthembi hoard contains coins of the Shaka ruler Nahapana restructured by Gautamiputra Satakarni - hard proof of his victory.
- Pushyamitra was NOT succeeded directly by the Kanva Vasudeva - the Shunga line ran on to Devabhuti first.
- Keep the two Vasudevas apart: Vasudeva founded the Kanva dynasty; Vasudeva I was the last great Kushana.

The foreign dynasties - Indo-Greeks to Kushanas

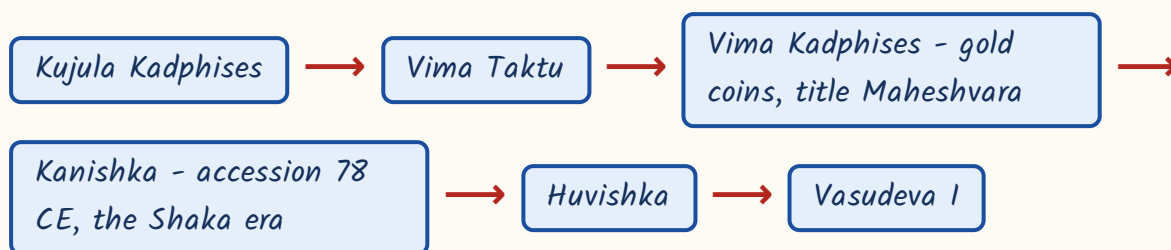
Between about 200 BCE and 200 CE, wave after wave came through the north-west - Indo-Greeks, then Shakas, then Parthians, then Kushanas. Remember them by their firsts, because that is how they are asked.

The four waves from the north-west



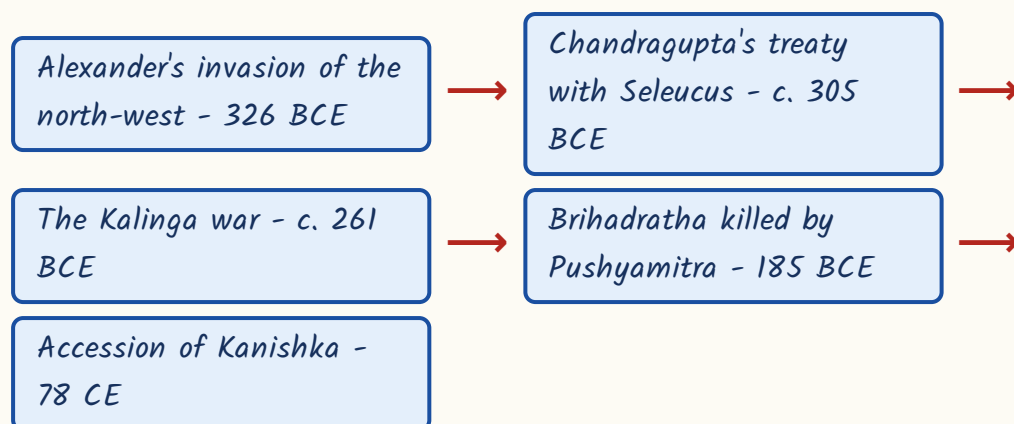
- The Indo-Greeks were the first rulers in India to issue coins bearing the king's portrait and name, and the first to issue gold coins.
- Menander, the Milinda of the Pali texts, was converted to Buddhism by the monk Nagasena - the dialogue is the Milindapanho.
- The Heliodorus or Garuda pillar at Besnagar near Vidisha was set up by Heliodorus, envoy of the Indo-Greek Antialcidas, at the court of Bhagabhadra. It is the earliest evidence of a Greek adopting Vaishnavism.
- Maues, also written Moga, was the first Shaka king in India.
- The Junagadh rock inscription of the Shaka ruler Rudradaman I, 150 CE, is the earliest long inscription in chaste Sanskrit.

The Kushana line



- Kanishka's capital was Purushapura, modern Peshawar; his second capital was Mathura.
- He convened the Fourth Buddhist Council in Kashmir under Vasumitra, which produced the Mahavibhasha.
- His court is associated with Ashvaghosha, Nagarjuna, the physician Charaka and the engineer Agesilaus.
- Kanishka's coins do carry an image of the Buddha - the statement that they never do is false.
- Bhavabhuti belongs to Harsha's period, centuries later. He is NOT of Kanishka's court.
- The Besnagar Garuda pillar goes with Heliodorus and Antialcidas, never with Kanishka.

The event chronology RPSC asks you to order



Art schools and the Sangam age

Two things close this chapter. First the three sculpture schools of the post-Mauryan centuries, which are asked as material-and-region matching. Second the Sangam age in the far south, which is a small but reliable one-liner source.

Gandhara vs Mathura - the two schools examiners set against each other

Gandhara	Mathura
North-west - Peshawar and Taxila region	Mathura, in the Ganga-Yamuna region
Grey schist	Spotted red sandstone from Sikri
Greco-Roman form on Buddhist subject matter	Indigenous form, wholly Indian tradition
Buddha with wavy hair, drapery in folds, sombre	Buddha shaven-headed, robe thin and close, smiling and robust
Buddhist subjects almost exclusively	Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical subjects alike
Patronised by the Kushanas	Also flourished under the Kushanas

The three schools by material and region

School	Material	Region
Gandhara	Grey schist	North-west

School	Material	Region
Mathura	Spotted red sandstone	Middle Ganga - Mathura
Amaravati	White limestone	Krishna valley

The Sangam age

The three Sangam kingdoms

Kingdom	Capital	Emblem and port
Chera	Vanji	Bow emblem; port Muziris
Chola	Uraiyur, also Puhar	Tiger emblem; Karikala built the Kallanai on the Kaveri
Pandya	Madurai	Fish emblem; port Korkai

- Tolkappiyam is the oldest extant work in Tamil - a work on grammar and poetics.
- The Sangam corpus includes the Ettuthogai, eight anthologies, and the Pattuppattu, ten idylls.
- The Silappadikaram was composed by Ilango Adigal; the Manimekalai by Sittalai Sattanar. These twin epics are post-Sangam.
- The Pandya emblem is the FISH. The tiger is the Chola. That swap is the standard wrong option.

YAAD RAKHO

Sangam emblems - Chera bends the Bow, Chola wears the Tiger's stripes, Pandya swims like a Fish. B-T-F in the order Chera, Chola, Pandya.

REVISION RECAP

1. Chandragupta c. 322-321 BCE with Kautilya, overthrew Dhana Nanda; treaty with Seleucus c. 305 BCE - four provinces for 500 elephants.
2. Arthashastra - 15 books, 180 prakaranas; found by R. Shamasastri 1905, published 1909.

3. Megasthenes' Indica - fragments only; seven-fold division of society; denies slavery; Pataliputra run by six boards of five.
4. Junagadh rock - Sudarshana lake built by Pushyagupta, conduits by Tushaspha, repaired by Rudradaman I in 150 CE; Bindusara = Amitraghata = Amitrochates, with Deimachus as Antiochus I's envoy at his court.
5. Ashoka acceded c. 268 BCE; Kalinga war c. 261 BCE, described in Major Rock Edict XIII, which names five Greek kings.
6. Titles Devanampiya and Piyadasi; personal name only at Maski, Gujjarra, Nettur and Udegolam; Brahmi deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837.
7. Kharoshthi at Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra; Greek and Aramaic at Kandahar; the two Separate Rock Edicts only at Dhauili and Jaugada.
8. Pillar Edict VII, the longest, only on Delhi-Topra; pillars of Chunar sandstone with Mauryan polish.
9. Bairat, Jaipur - minor rock edict on Bijak-ki-Pahari plus the Bhabru edict found by Captain Burt, now in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata.
10. Bhabru is the only edict where Ashoka professes faith in the Buddha, Dhamma and Sangha; Bairat has India's earliest free-standing circular Buddhist chaitya, dug by Daya Ram Sahni.
11. Rummindei - Lumbini exempted from bali, produce share one-eighth. Nigalisagar - stupa of Konakamana enlarged.
12. Barabar caves (Sudama, Vishvakarma, Karan Chaupar) given by Ashoka to the Ajivikas; Nagarjuni caves by Dasharatha; Lomas Rishi has the doorway but no Ashokan inscription.
13. Sarnath lion capital adopted as the State Emblem on 26 January 1950; abacus with lion, elephant, horse and bull between dharmachakras.
14. Officials - Samaharta revenue, Sannidhata treasury, Rajuka rural justice, Nagaraka city, Dhamma Mahamatta from the 14th regnal year.
15. Provinces - Uttarapatha/Taxila, Avantiratha/Ujjain, Kalinga/Tosali, Dakshinapatha/Suvarnagiri; capital Pataliputra.
16. Brihadratha killed 185 BCE by Pushyamitra Shunga; Kanva founded by Vasudeva c. 73 BCE after Devabhuti; Kharavela's Hathigumpha inscription, Udayagiri.
17. Satavahanas - Simuka, capital Pratishthana; metonymics; first to grant land to brahmanas; Nashik prashasti of Gautami Balashri, Jogalthembi hoard.
18. Indo-Greeks first with portrait coins and gold coins; Menander and Nagasena in the Milindapanho; Heliodorus pillar at Besnagar for Antialcidas; Maues first Shaka.
19. Kushanas - Kujula, Vima Taktu, Vima Kadphises, Kanishka (78 CE, Shaka era), Huvishka, Vasudeva I; Purushapura capital; Fourth Council in Kashmir under Vasumitra.

20. Gandhara grey schist, Mathura spotted red sandstone, Amaravati white limestone; Sangam - Chera/Vanji/bow, Chola/Uraiyur/tiger, Pandya/Madurai/fish; Tolkappiyam oldest Tamil work.